

De Robertis Pasticceria: A Living Portrait of Italian-American Heritage at 176 First Avenue

This evocative historical photograph captures the vibrant essence of **De Robertis Pasticceria**, a cherished Italian bakery located at **176 First Avenue**, a cornerstone of New York's East Village from **1904 to 2014**. Founded by **Paolo De Robertis**, an immigrant from Puglia, Italy, the bakery became a beloved gathering place for generations of Italian-Americans and local residents for over a century.

The sepia-toned image, likely taken in the early 20th century, presents a richly detailed view of the shop's exterior. The signage proudly announces: *"Caffè Pugliese – Vito De Robertis, Prop. – Pasticceria"*, reflecting both regional pride and personal ownership. Behind the elegant, curtain-framed windows, rows of elaborately decorated cakes and pastries hint at the craftsmanship within. Traditional Italian confections like **sfogliatella**, **cannoli**, and **ossi di morto** were mainstays, prepared using recipes handed down through generations.

Outside the shop, the neighborhood scene comes alive. Men in flat caps exchange conversation, while a young boy scrubs the stoop—a glimpse into the daily rhythms of immigrant life. The mosaic tile threshold and fine detailing of the storefront reflect the artistry not only of the pastries but also of the establishment itself. Above, a sign advertises *"Office to Let – Suitable for Doctor or Dentist"*, signaling the building's mixed-use character, typical of early 20th-century New York.

Historical records from the **1930 Bromley Land Book** confirm that 176 First Avenue stood amid a bustling block of 1- to 7-story buildings, underscoring the blend of commercial vitality and residential density that defined the neighborhood. The area was a hub for Italian immigrants, later joined by other communities including Polish and Ukrainian, as evidenced by nearby institutions like **St. Vladimir's Church** and the **Elizabeth Home for Girls**.

Though De Robertis closed its doors in 2014, third-generation owner **Annie De Robertis** recalled: *"What kept us alive is that through everything, we always used the finest, freshest ingredients, using recipes passed down through generations."* This photograph captures that legacy—a time capsule of devotion, community, and the enduring flavor of home.